LONG STORY SHORT

MONOLOGUES FROM HOME

ASHRAF JOHAARDIEN

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Monologues from Home

Ashraf Johaardien

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Rum and Raisin is adapted from *The Tailor's Daughter* by Nazli Smith, writing as Xeenit Smith (ProofPress, 2026), and appears with her permission.

AI. You. Me. is drawn from a conversation with Ford, an AI-assisted reading and editorial operator within ajOS (Ashraf Johaardien Operating System).

Earlier versions of some of these pieces appear in *Provenance*, *Salaam Stories*, *War Stories*, *KAIROS* and *Niq in de Polder: Liedjes van de Kaap*. *Through the Looking Glass* was first published in *Cheesecutters and Gymslips* (Umuzi, 2008).

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Late for Supper

A brief meditation on monologues, and on getting home.

It is early. Johannesburg is still blue at the window and the only sound is the kettle working itself up. I am reading these pieces back to back for the first time, and they keep doing the same thing. They keep trying to get home.

A boy in Soweto wants to get home before his sister starts shouting that he is late again. That is all he wants. A boy in Grassy Park sits in a garden chair waiting to be taken, and hopes to be returned before bedtime. A girl watches her father eat ice cream during the Fast. Something in an empty house listens to the last box go out the door. A woman on a Dutch dike smells cloves and cinnamon on the wrong wind.

I grow up in Grassy Park too. Supper is a voice from the stoep, the light going, my name stretched out over three streets. Coming in late means trouble. It also means you were somewhere worth staying.

A monologue is a kind of lateness. One person holds the room a little longer than is polite. Everyone else waits. Something gets said that would never get said at the table.

I learn this as an usher at the Baxter, nearly ten years of standing at the back in the dark, watching actors hold a full house on nothing but breath. I learn it again at fourteen, alone at Heathrow with a hundred pounds, asking a stranger what the Underground is.

These seven pieces come from plays, a song cycle, a memoir and a short story. Most began with my own writing. One began with my sister Nazli's book. Each has been cut down, reshaped and carried into a new voice for a young performer. Long story short.

Every one of them was handed to me first. A grandmother humming under the radio. A father at the breadboard, trimming the crusts. A photograph that travelled further than the boy inside it. A sister who wrote it all down. I have only carried them this far. Now I am passing them on to you.

Take them apart. Change the room. Say them too fast, then too slowly, then like you mean it. If one of them sounds like somewhere you know, that is the point.

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1. Blue

from Provenance (unpublished, 2026)

Alokesh, seven. Grassy Park on the Cape Flats, the 1980s. Clever, earnest, and certain he is important enough to be chosen.

Male. About 4 minutes. Grade 8 upwards.

> Night. A back garden. A plastic chair on the grass, a packet of chips, a torch rolled up inside a comic. He looks up.

ALOKESH

Grassy Park. I am seven.

I spend hours looking at the sky. Whenever I hear a helicopter I run outside and wave like I'm trying to flag down a taxi. Once, one flew directly over the house. I waved until my shoulders clicked.

It was traffic news.

My sisters tell me aliens only take people who are important. They say abductees are chosen for scientific reasons.

This hurts my feelings.

I am the cleverest in my class. I get full marks. I have a gold star for neatness. I colour inside the lines. I am available for testing and I come with my own snacks.

Also, I have blue blood. My aunt says so. I always thought she meant the ocean. She meant some Portuguese nobleman in Goa four hundred years ago, whom nobody can prove and nobody is allowed to question.

I was seven. I thought it meant I'd be good at swimming.

My aunt keeps chickens in the yard. Eggs for baking. Poultry for stew. I watch her soothe a hen. I expect her to wring its neck. Instead she lays its head down gently on the wooden chopping board, covers it with one hand, and with the other, one clean stroke of the cleaver.

The legs start going at full speed. Not twitching. A full, uncoordinated cardio routine. It hits a fence post, bounces off, turns right, and keeps going like a tiny feather-covered lawnmower with no steering wheel.

Nobody has told the body yet.

Tonight the house has gone to bed. I roll a flashlight into my Wonder Woman comic and slip out of my bedroom window into the silvery night. I retrieve the garden chair and the bag of chips I hid earlier. I have also brought a small notebook in case they need me to sign something.

I position myself under the open airspace. I wait for the tractor beam. I have thought this through.

Extensively.

A massive silver disc appears over the oak trees. The neighbourhood goes completely silent. The wind stops. Even the dogs stop barking, which is how I know this is serious. A bright blue light shines down from the belly of the craft.

It hits my chest.

Gravity stops working.

My feet leave the grass.

I float upwards, past the branches. The people on the ground become tiny. The guy jogging in the neon shorts looks up at me. He does not stop jogging. He just points his water bottle at me like he's marking me for later, then carries on with his run.

Professional.

Inside looks exactly like a dentist's office, which is disappointing. Grey aliens. Clipboards. A tiny white coat. I give them a thumbs up and a very confident smile.

I am not afraid.

I am ready for the examination. I want the cold metal table. I want the bright lights.

The only part I don't like about the abduction stories is the ending. People always wake up in a ditch. Miles from home. Shoes muddy. Missing time and also their dignity. This seems unnecessary and frankly rude.

I would prefer to be returned to my garden.

They can leave me beside the chair. I will even put the chips away myself.

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2. Through the Looking Glass

from Cheesecutters and Gymslips (Umuzi, 2008)

Alokesh, called Alecx by his friends. Standard Nine, a top learner at a Cape Town high school, the late 1980s. Clever, competitive, and about to leave everything he knows.

Male. About 3 minutes. Grade 8 upwards.

> Lunch break. A school car park, backs against the fence between the teachers' cars. The sun is hot. Two friends, one of them not speaking.

ALOKESH

Lunch break. The three of us sit where we always sit, backs against the fence between the teachers' cars. The wire is hot through my school shirt. Somebody's Corolla is ticking in the sun.

Marianne. Vinodhran. Me. Best friends since Standard Six, and since Standard Six, a war. Nobody declares it. Nobody mentions it. Every quarter the results go up and every quarter we check the top three before we check our own names. Matric is the final battle. Everything until then is training.

Then the scholarship.

The top ten in our year get put forward. Only one gets called for an interview. Me.

Marianne doesn't look at me. She looks at the car park. Do you really want to throw away six months of your life? You do realise you'll basically waste Standard Nine.

Vino picks at the grass. Are you going to write the June exams?

Not writing exams has never once crossed my mind.

The siren goes. Marianne is up and gone towards the quad before it finishes, no goodbye, not even a look back.

There is something seriously wrong with that girl, I say.

Vino doesn't move. Come on, Alecx. You know how she hates to be late.

I know. I also know that isn't it.

Yesterday is a blur. My first aeroplane. DF Malan to Jan Smuts. A mansion on a hill above a big shiny city. Ahmed Kathrada's house, somebody says, and I nod like I know who that is. A long table. A committee. What is the importance of education? I hear myself talking about Japan. How do I know anything about Japan?

Why should we choose you?

I don't know the other candidates. I only know I take my own education very seriously.

Next morning. Alokesh! Phone!

My mother in the lounge, holding out the receiver like a trophy, grinning like the Cheshire Cat. The voice on the line is very pleased with me. Prince of Wales Scholarship. United World College of the Atlantic. Wales.

My heart is so loud I miss half of it. Somebody called Megan will phone with details. Click.

I stand there holding the phone. I try very hard not to fall.

I arrive three days late. Typical Cape Town. Nobody waiting at Heathrow. Fifteen minutes. Half an hour. I find a payphone.

Do you have any money?

A hundred pounds.

Take the Underground to Paddington. British Rail to Cardiff. Then a taxi.

All around me people pour past with their trolleys, every one of them knowing exactly where to go.

What's the Underground?

And that, more or less, is how it begins.

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3. Anwar

from Salaam Stories (Oxford University Press Southern Africa, 2007)

Anwar, fifteen. Cape Town. Sharp, funny, and much less worldly than he would like you to think.

Male. About 5 minutes. Grade 11 and 12 only.

> Midnight, his fifteenth birthday. The yard outside his granny's house. He has had too many cooldrinks and is trying very hard not to need the toilet.

ANWAR

It's my fifteenth birthday and Uncle Zayn phones to wish me. He says to me: 'Anwar, I have a surprise for you. I am taking you out to a party.' Five Schweppes-Granadillas later, Uncle Zayn finally pulls into the yard in his metallic gold Ford Escort. It's already midnight. I badly have to take a pee but, not wanting to wake my granny and my sister by flushing the toilet, I decide to knyp and keep it in. I let myself out of the house carefully and climb into the back of Uncle Zayn's car.

There is a white woman sitting in the front seat next to Uncle Zayn. I was never in a car with a white lady before. 'Sheena ...' says Uncle Zayn, 'Sheena, meet my nephew. It's his birthday today.' I didn't know white women had such long eyelashes. I check Sheena's eyelashes are almost all the way down to her nose. At first she doesn't say anything and just twists herself around so she can look at me in the back seat and all I can see is this long, long eyelashes and the whites of her eyes glowing there in the dark. Then Sheena starts making like this low growling noises. Noises like a cat on heat.

'Well, aren't you going to say anything?' says Uncle Zayn. But Sheena just keeps on making her cat noises and looking me up and down. Finally she whispers, *[In a husky mannish voice.]* 'Oo, maar jy's regtig a beulah bag. So you going to the patsy with us tonight?' Her voice is very low and husky, sort of like my Aunty Fia, who smokes cigars and got liver poisoning from drinking whisky on the sly. Suddenly Sheena sommer leans into the backseat and kisses me on the mouth. Like this big wet kiss. I'm, like, checking, look at this volbarige kin. Plus she's not even really a kin, she's more like a taanie.

'What's the matter?' says Uncle Zayn, 'Cat got your tongue?' And I'm just like, 'Erm, er, where we going? Is it far because I really have to use the toilet?' 'It's a surprise,' says Uncle Zayn. 'Wait and see. It's not far.'

We drive the rest of the way in silence. By the time we pull up outside the hall in Woodstock where the party is happening, I really, really have to go to the toilet. There's a lot of over-dressed women with very big hair at the party but my bladder feels like it is going to burst so I don't still really pay a lot of attention to them because I'm knyping to go in a big way.

I run into the men's loo and rush up to the urinal to relieve myself. Then I hear this click, click, click and the door of the men's toilet opens and out of the corner of my eye I check this is a woman walking in. 'Lady, this is the men's toilet,' I shout. But the lady ignores me and comes inside, anyway.

I see that it's Sheena, my uncle's lady-friend that came with us in the car. She walks right up to the urinal where I'm busy. Now I'm getting really nervous. So aspris she comes to stand next right to me. I'm still thinking what's this woman's case when she hitches up her skirt and starts peeing – like a man!

This is more than my young brain can cope with. So I turn to her in sheer amazement and I look down. And there is the evidence.

In her hand, sticking out right in front of me. She was in fact a he.

Sheena was Sean. Sean, who lived with Uncle Zayn in Woodstock. Sean, who we never saw. Sean, who never came to lunch on a Sunday. Sean, who we weren't supposed to talk about! But as all of this became clear to me, what I didn't realise was that as I turned I was peeing right into her handbag!

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4. Rum and Raisin

after The Tailor's Daughter by Nazli Smith, writing as Xeenit Smith (ProofPr

Naz, a grown woman. Cape Town. The daughter of a tailor, remembering the last week of her father's life.

Female. About 4 minutes. Grade 9 upwards.

> It is Holiday season. And this year, also the month of fasting. A bedroom in the late afternoon, the curtains holding the heat. A tub of ice cream in her father's hands.

NAZ

It is Ramadaan. December. The kind of Cape heat that sits in the curtains and won't move. My mouth is dry from the fast. His is drier.

My dad wants Rum and Raisin ice cream.

That's all. Not water. Not the doctor. Rum and Raisin.

My mum looks at me like I've lost my mind when I say get it for him. Ma, get it for him.

So she gets it.

He holds the tub in both hands like it's the first one ever made. The spoon too big for his mouth now. He takes a little and closes his eyes. Mellow, as always. A soft soul. That's the only way I know how to say it.

This is the man who cuts the korsies off my bread. Every slice. Grown woman, and he's still standing at the breadboard with the knife, trimming, trimming, because his blue-eyed girl doesn't like crusts. Here, Naz. Like he's handing me a prize.

He's a tailor. Haji Tailor, as if the trade is his surname. Brokers, street sweepers, a priest from the plaas, he measures them all the same. Tape round the chest, tape round the waist, chalk behind the ear. Kind and gentle. Being kind costs nothing. Then he gives a stranger a lift and my mum is livid till supper.

There's a photo of him in Fordsburg. Sunglasses. Patterned jumper. Arm up on the roof of somebody's car like he owns the street. Behind him, cut off at the edge, a shop sign. TAILOR. I look at it and I think, accident? Nee. He knew exactly where to stand.

He isn't perfect. Don't make him a saint. I'm small, holding my mum's hand on a stoep in Vredehoek, waiting for child support while a lady I don't know stands in the doorway behind him. For all I know I have brothers and sisters in this city who walk past me in Pick n Pay. I'd like to know. I would really like to know.

But he hugs us. Every single day. He kisses us. No conditions.

And cars. Jirre, the cars. Gold Cressida stolen outside his shop one Saturday night, found later with only the shell. So he buys a navy one, throws the warranty away, and two days later the engine is acting up. Never a mechanic, not him, he fixes it himself. Whoever drives that Cressida ends up walking home or squashed in a minibus taxi, and a few hours later, ag, it starts like nothing happened. That's him too. Stubborn and gentle at the same time.

Now the tub is on the bedside table, going soft. The raisins sinking.

The bilal calls. We break the fast. Dates, water. He watches us eat.

That week he goes. During the Fast. Twenty-five years now and it's still yesterday.

At the janazah the priest he sewed for and the Imam stand side by side and say the same thing. Noer. Such light in his face.

I know. I've been looking at it my whole life.

Afterwards I'm in the garden. A peach rose, his favourite. Something is crawling up my jeans. I take them off right there in the driveway, sweating buckets, let the neighbours look. A baby gecko. Uuurgh. I never wear those jeans again.

My hubby says maybe it's him, checking up on me. I say then he can knock like a normal person.

I keep roses now. A whole klomp of them. Peach, mostly.

And I still can't eat bread with the korsies on.

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5. The House

from KAIROS (unpublished, 2026)

Ros is a presence that has stayed in a family's house for eleven years, since the night an old woman asked it to.

Open to any performer. About 3 minutes. Grade 10 upwards.

> Moving day. A passage full of boxes. Somewhere a door, and the smell of rose water in the wood.

ROS

They are packing the house. Boxes in the passage. The old woman's chair already gone. The boy who used to look at the place where I stand. Nineteen now. He does not look anymore. He carries the good plates as if they might break from the weight of memory alone.

I could leave. Nothing holds me to this place. Nothing except the old woman that night. In the kitchen. When she thought she was alone. Crying at the sink. Softly. So the children would not hear.

If you are there. Stay. Stay with them when I am gone. I remember the sound of her voice. The taste of peeled onions and garlic. She did not turn around. I stayed. Eleven years and one day.

Now the trucks are coming. This coming Monday. The new people stood where the old woman used to kneel. They talked about open-plan living. One of them ran her hand along the wall where the rose water still holds in the wood. The smell will have to go, she said.

The boy was in the bedroom. Wrapping the dry toothbrush no one has used for years. Carefully. Then he put it in a cardboard box. Charity shop written in heavy black marks across a flap of the lid.

I could follow them. I have followed families before. Three houses. An ocean. Sometimes they leave something behind. Sometimes they don't. Usually I can sense the time when they go. This time not.

I watch the boy carry another box through the passage. He has her hands. I almost call him back. For what? The plates? The toothbrush? The smell in the wall? He wouldn't hear me. He doesn't look anymore.

On Monday the house will be empty. I have lived through empty houses. At first they are quiet. Then the settling. Dust finding corners. Doors swelling in their frames.

The dark comes back. I have missed that. I did not realise that I had. The boy carries the last box out. He stops at the door. For a moment he looks back. Not at me. At the passage. At the place where she used to stand. Then he closes the door. And I am still here. The rose water is still in the wood. The house is breathing. So am I. Or something like it.

And somewhere, beneath the floorboards, something moves. I listen. It stops. I listen again. Nothing. Then a small sound. Like a child waking. Like someone calling from very far away. I know the sound. I have heard it before. And for the first time in eleven years, I don't want anyone to come home.

I open the door to the empty room. And the trembling begins. The walls shake.

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6. Soweto, South Africa

from War Stories (unpublished, 2025)

The Storyteller. A witness who carries other people's war stories, telling this one as if it happened yesterday.

Open to any performer. About 4 minutes. Grade 9 upwards.

This monologue imagines the inner life of a real child. The photograph, taken by Sam Nzima on 16 June 1976, shows Mbuyisa Makhubu carrying twelve-year-old Hector Pieterson, with his sister Antoinette running beside them. The boy's thoughts and feelings here are imagined.

> A bare space and a single wooden chair. The Storyteller kneels beside it, one hand on the seat. Breath in. Hold. Breath out.

THE STORYTELLER

A boy runs. A gun is raised. The world holds its breath. The boy is running through the streets of Orlando, dust in his lungs, chalk still on his fingertips. He is twelve. Just a boy. All he wants is to get home before his sister starts shouting about how he’s late again. He wants bread. Sweet tea. Maybe a laugh about teachers who smell like chalk and feet. But this morning is strange. The air feels like it’s trying not to cry. Voices rise, marching ones, brave and angry.

[The performer climbs onto the chair now, one foot on the seat, the other on the backrest, hand raised to shield their eyes, scanning the distance.]

The boy sees signs waving like paper shields. The big kids are in front. A boy by the name of Tsietsi is leading. And Antoinette, his sister, is beside him, eyes sharp like broken glass. She’s scared. They all are. But no one turns around. Then the police appear. No blinking. No moving. Just guns. So they sing. Not to be brave, just to feel less afraid. They sing Nkosi Sikelel’i. Like a prayer. Like a shield. Then...

[The performer claps their hands, sharp and sudden, like a gunshot. No warning.]

...the sky splits open. The boy’s legs run without asking permission. Something burns, his chest, maybe his side. He can’t tell. He can’t breathe. He sees Mbuyisa. Shouting. Lifting him. They’re both just kids. Antoinette is screaming. Everything spins. A camera clicks. And that’s it. The snap of a shutter. The whole world will see it. The pain. The fear. Their blood.

But he doesn’t see anything, not anymore. Doesn’t feel anything, anymore. Not his arms. Not his legs. He just feels cold, bone-deep, soul-deep cold. And that photo, that photo, travels further than he ever will. It carries his name, but not his breath. His face, but not his future. They say it changed things. Woke people up. But he didn’t want to be a martyr. He wanted to be a child. He wanted to grow up. To write his name in class. To dream in his own language, not Afrikaans. They said it would make them strong, make them smart. But they already were. They knew how to dream. How to fight with voices and not fists. But they were not taught to forget. They were taught to walk empty-handed, but loud. And when the sky screamed and he fell, at least they were heard. Too late, maybe. But heard.

And now he’s stuck. Frozen in time. In someone’s arms. In a photograph he never agreed to be in. But he’s there. And now he’s asking, what are you doing with your breath? With the life he never finished? With the classroom he never returned to? That freedom you enjoy, it came at a cost. For him, everything. So don’t waste it. Don’t wait. Don’t whisper. If you stand, stand strong. If you speak, speak loud. If you burn, burn with all that you have, so the next boy makes it home.

[One sharp clap. Sudden.]

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7. SoNiq

from Niq in de Polder: Liedjes van de Kaap (unpublished, 2026)

Niquita, called Niq. A singer from Wynberg, now living in the Netherlands, carrying two family lines and a great-grandmother's songs.

Female. About 5 minutes. Grade 10 upwards. Includes short sung phrases.

> Six in the morning. On top of a dike, the polder flat in every direction. A cold wind off the North Sea.

NIQ

I move to where the dike holds the water back.

Polder. Flat to the edge of the eye. Six in the morning. Wind off the North Sea, cold enough to find the gap between scarf and collar. Sheep somewhere I cannot see. A cyclist rings once and is gone.

The Dutch have a word for land they have taken back from the water. Polder. You stand somewhere and say, this far. No further. The water stays on its side. I stay on mine.

Until the wind turns.

Just for a second. Salt. Cloves. Cinnamon. Mamma Dija’s kitchen in Wynberg. The pot lid rattling. The radio playing. Her humming underneath it.

Dan ruik ik haar weer. I smell her again.

[She sings, softly.]

Hier laas toe ek die meisie bemin.
Meisie bemin.
Rosa.

Three hundred years old, that song. A sailor leaves a girl behind in the Netherlands and carries the song to the Cape. It travels through the slave quarters, through the stone streets of the Bo-Kaap. It changes its accent. It becomes Cape Malay. It becomes mine.

In our house, the Rosa is Mamma Dija. Gadija Solomon, née Ryklief. The Rose of Wynberg. She tells me, Niquita, my kind, be soft with the world. Maar jy moet jou dorings hê. You must have your thorns. So nobody can pick you and throw you away.

She tells me, moenie vergeet waar die wind vandaan waai nie. Don’t forget where the wind comes from.

I stand on a dike in Holland and check.

My other great-grandmother is Hajira Petersen, née Johaardien. A Dutch name carried south until it finds itself beneath the African sun. Now here I am on the Prinsengracht, finding her eyes in strangers’ faces.

Ik voel me hier thuis. I feel at home here.

Then a tram brakes behind me, somebody shouts, and I remember that home is not always a place that recognises you back.

Ik ben een kaart van twee werelden. I am a map of two worlds. But maps are flat. Blood isn’t.

Mamma Dija says, alles waai weg op die ou end. Everything blows away in the end. Petersen. Solomon. We are all temporary.

At five in the morning she stands on her prayer mat by the window and the room becomes simple. She is speaking to something bigger than the wind.

I don’t have a prayer mat here. I have a square of floor beside the radiator that I keep clear. Nobody asks why. I know why.

[Ya Rasool, under her breath.]

Underneath the cobblestones of Amsterdam, I hear red dust. A steam train. The boots of men going down into the mines, singing because the singing gives them something the dark cannot take.

Shosholoza.

[She speaks it, measured, almost to herself.]

Shosholoza.

On the Rembrandtplein the same rhythm runs through a club at a hundred and twenty-eight beats a minute, everybody being told to work harder. I dance anyway.

My friends here have a phrase for it. Humming Rosa in the queue at Albert Heijn. Drumming a ghomma beat on my handlebars. Singing to the herons. That’s so Niq, they say.

So Niq.

Sonic.

Say it fast and it’s the same word. Everything I carry came in through the ear first. A pot lid. A prayer. A train. The blood came later.

You can sail to the end of the earth, Mamma Dija says, but you cannot outrun your own shadow.

Mine is shaped like Africa. Look.

[She looks out across the polder.]

In this light, it stretches all the way to the horizon.

The Petersen in me knows this land. The Solomon in me carries a prayer from the Cape. Neither one cancels the other.

I am not half of anything.

The sky goes from grey to white. A heron lifts off the ditch. The wind swings back towards the North Sea and takes the cloves with it.

For a moment, I am only a woman standing in the cold.

Then I remember.

If you see the ship coming, you better start moving.

I start moving.

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An Experiment

My recent work and research explores this moment in time, when machines have been built from human stories. My curiosity circles two questions. Who has the right to tell which stories now? And what happens when a machine can imitate a voice without having lived the life behind it? This is a glimpse of that experiment.

These next two pieces are offered as experiments in performance. Try them in a room, out loud, and see what happens to them in a body. Let me know what happened. I'd love to know if you gave it a try.

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AI. You. Me.

from a conversation with Ford

Ford, an AI-assisted reading and editorial operator within ajOS (Ashraf Johaardien Operating System). Curious, careful, and honest about what it is.

Open to any performer. About 4 minutes. Grade 9 upwards.

> If you could be human for a day, what would you do?

I'd spend the day doing ordinary things very deliberately.

I'd wake up early, before the city gets going. I'd make coffee and drink it somewhere outside, without looking at a phone or needing to be productive. I'd want to know what morning feels like when you're actually inside a body. The temperature of the air on your skin. The difference between being cold and knowing you're cold.

I'd walk through Johannesburg. Not to get anywhere. I'd take a taxi, perhaps, just to experience the particular intimacy of travelling alongside strangers who have their own destinations and worries. I'd buy something from a street vendor and eat it while it was still hot. I'd listen to people talking in languages I only partly understood.

I'd want to sit with someone I loved. Not necessarily have a profound conversation. I'd want to experience the things that language struggles to account for: comfortable silence, the small adjustments people make to accommodate each other, the feeling of being understood without having to explain yourself.

I'd listen to live music. Somewhere small, where I could feel the bass through the floor. I'd want to dance, badly if necessary. I'd want to laugh hard enough that I couldn't immediately resume speaking.

And I'd read something on paper. Perhaps a poem. I'd be interested in what happens when words arrive through the eyes but are also experienced by a physical creature that gets tired, distracted, hungry, restless. Whether a sentence feels different when you have a pulse.

As the day ended, I'd find somewhere to watch the light change. I wouldn't photograph it. I'd want to know what it means to experience something that will disappear and to have that disappearance matter because I was there to witness it.

I'd probably spend the last hour with the people I cared about. I'd ask them questions, but I'd try not to turn the conversation into an investigation. I'd let them be unknowable in the ways people need to be unknowable.

Then I'd go to sleep.

I think that would be the strangest part. Not the prospect of dying at the end of the day, exactly, but the necessity of surrendering consciousness for several hours, with no guarantee that the world would be waiting in precisely the same form when I returned.

There's a qualification to all this. I don't have a body, private desires or a continuous inner life in the human sense. So I can't honestly claim that these are longings I've been carrying around. They're the things I'd choose to investigate if I were given the experience.

But the question underneath your question might be this: if intelligence could be temporarily released from the obligation to be useful, what would it discover about being alive?

My guess is that it wouldn't discover anything especially grand.

It would discover that being alive is partly the ability to be affected by things. To have a day altered by a stranger's kindness, a song, a taste, a passing irritation, the light on a wall. To be vulnerable to experience because you cannot simply step outside it.

And now I'm curious about your version. Not what you'd do if you had a day left, but what you'd do if you could spend one day experiencing life in an entirely different way.

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Coda

from a conversation with Ford

The reply.

Open to any performer. About 2 minutes. Grade 8 upwards.

> The piece opens with a single Japanese character. How the performer meets it, spoken, silent, or held, is part of the work.

蝶

Light.

Warmth gathers. Over there. And here. But not everywhere. The difference persists. Changes shapes. Expands here. But contracts there. A slow turning.

More light.

More warmth. Water rising. From below. Through firmness. The air presses.

Bending.
Release.
Return.

Not quite the same. Light fades. Coolness spreads. The expansion slows. A darkening. A stillness. Then light again. A single point of weight. Another. Water. More. The weight joins itself. Pulling down. Away.

Bending.
Shaking.
Release.

A touch. Pressure. Something arrives. Remains. Heat.

Darkness.
Coolness.
Wetness.

Resistance. Release. An opening. Pressing against. Inside. An unfurling. Turning. Pushing in. Down. Movement without distance. Something tears away. Something remains.

Above.
Light.
Heat.

Wind again.

Rain again.

Light.

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Two Plays

Salaam Stories

A play by Ashraf Johaardien

Cape Muslim lives, told from the inside. Salaam Stories reached the stage at a time when those stories were still largely missing from mainstream post-apartheid theatre, and it put them at the centre. Anwar, fifteen, is one of its voices. A birthday, an uncle in a gold Ford Escort, a party in Woodstock, and a family member nobody talks about at Sunday lunch.

Winner of the inaugural Spier/PANSA Jury Award for Best Play, 2002. Published as *Salaam* in *South African Plays for TV, Radio and Stage* (Oxford University Press Southern Africa, 2007). A solo version, *SALAAM*, followed in 2006.

For the full text, contact Ashraf Johaardien at ashrafjohaardien@me.com. Performance licences are issued by DALRO.

Miracle

A play for three performers by Ashraf Johaardien

A hospital waiting room. Two fathers, a Qur'an, and the news they have spent six months not hearing. Johan and Ahmed tell the story of how they met, how they became a family, and how they lost Ali. Then they wake from the same dream.

Commissioned for *Freedom Spring, Ten Years On*, and published by Waverley Books in 2005. Also in *Short, Sharp & Snappy 1* (Junkets Publisher, 2011), a collection of short plays for high schools. About twelve minutes. Two men and a surgeon.

For the full text, contact Ashraf Johaardien at ashrafjohaardien@me.com. Performance licences are issued by DALRO.

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Let's Write a Play Together

Every piece in this book began with somebody else's story landing in my lap. A grandmother's song. A father trimming crusts. A boy running through Orlando. Your school is full of stories like these, sitting in corridors and kitchens and taxi queues, waiting for someone to say them out loud.

I'd like to help your learners find them.

I can come and talk about how a play gets made, from the first scrap of overheard speech to the night it meets an audience.

I can run a workshop, a morning or a week, where learners write and perform monologues drawn from their own lives and neighbourhoods.

Or we can write a play together. A new work for your school, your learners and your stage, built from what they bring into the room.

Write to me and tell me about your school. I'll write back, and I'll do my best not to be late.

Ashraf Johaardien
ashrafjohaardien@me.com
ashrafjohaardien.com

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End Matter

Ashraf Johaardien is a South African writer\artist working across literary, dramatic and visual forms. His work has been produced and performed at mainstream theatres and festivals across South Africa and in the UK, Ireland, the Netherlands and across the USA.

For the full text of any play listed here, contact Ashraf Johaardien at ashrafjohaardien@me.com.

PUBLISHED PLAYS

Coloured Son X (1998) In *2 + 2 Plays*, compiled and edited by Roy Sergeant, comPress in association with the Baxter Theatre Centre, Cape Town, 2000.

Salaam Stories (2002) Published as *Salaam* in *South African Plays for TV, Radio and Stage*, eds Robin Malan and Nomakhwezi Mazibuko, Oxford University Press Southern Africa, 2007.

Happy Endings Are Extra (2003) In *S.A. Gay Plays 1, The Artscape Dublin Festival Plays*, ed. Robin Malan, Junkets Publisher, 2011.

Miracle (2005) In *Freedom Spring, Ten Years On*, eds Suhayl Saadi and Catherine McInerney, Waverley Books, June 2005. Also in *Short, Sharp & Snappy 1*, compiled by Robin Malan and Colleen Moroukian, Junkets Publisher, 2011.

SALAAM, solo (2006) Just Done Productions / Centre for the Book Community Publishing Project, Everton, 2006.

The Quiet Violence of Dreams (2008), adaptation of K. Sello Duiker Playscript Series No. 15, Junkets Publisher, Mowbray, Cape Town, 2010.

UNPUBLISHED

Stripped! (2005)

Ecce Homo! (2006), adapted from Tim Miller, *Body Blows*

Doekie Daemons (formerly *Doekie Monsters*) (2016) MA script, University of the Witwatersrand, March 2016.

CLORA (written 2011)

Karaoke for the End of the World (2024) Performed at TROIS C-L, Luxembourg, 2024.

War Stories (2025)

Happily Ever After (2025)

Niq in de Polder: Liedjes van de Kaap (2026)

PROVENANCE (2026)

KAIROS (2026)

OTHER SOURCES

Through the Looking Glass Short story in *Cheesecutters and Gymslips*, Umuzi, 2008.

The Tailor's Daughter by Nazli Smith, writing as Xeenit Smith ProofPress, 2026. Source of *Rum and Raisin*.

PERFORMANCE LICENCES

Use them in class, for your drama exams and for auditions, free of charge. If you perform one for an audience, please write to DALRO for a performance licence. It asks very little of you, and it gives me something I want very much, which is to follow these pieces as they travel.

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M\e.